Titanic

By Christopher Durang

CHARACTERS:

Victoria Tammurai – Very British, but turns hick when angry
Richard Tammurai – Foreign Accent (pick a funny one that is incongruous)
Teddy Tammurai – Their son who is a regular guy
Lidia/Harriet/Annabella – Very sultry – the Sigourney Weaver type
The Captain – A pirate voice
Higgins, the sailor – Cockney accent (like the Beatles)

VICTORIA: Richard, listen, they're playing our song (she sings a little.) "Nearer my God to thee, Floating across the sea." The merry-go-round was playing that tune when I first conceived Teddy. Did you know that, Teddy?

TEDDY: No.

VICTORIA: Of course you didn't. You were too young. Yes, your father was quite a devil on the merry-go-round.

RICHARD: I still am

VICTORIA: Although you developed a bad case of vertigo the last time we rode the Wild Mouse.

RICHARD: I've never ridden the Wild Mouse.

VICTORIA: (a take; change subject) Teddy has very hair legs for a fourteen-year-old. Do you think that's right, Richard?

RICHARD: Teddy hasn't been fourteen for years.

VICTORIA: Even so. Teddy, sit up. People will think you're fourteen years old. Why weren't we placed at the Captain's table. Granted the passenger list is impressive, but I think we are still among the crème de la crème. We're certainly rich enough.

RICHARD: Perhaps the Captain looked into your family background.

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VICTORIA: I would not have set one foot upon this boat if I had thought you were going to persist in these endless cruelties. Richard, I want a divorce. As soon as we dock, I am going straight to my solicitor.

RICHARD: Victoria, as far as I am concerned you can go right back to the pig farms of Indiana. Somehow I wish we had never come on the Titanic.

INTRODUCTION

Titanic by Christopher Durang takes us into the heart of children's anger with their parents and parents' manipulation of their children. We find that laughter is the best surgery, slicing through prejudice and hypocrisy, cutting out dead beliefs and inflamed opinions. This dark comedy, lit by lightning bolts of truth and humor, is among the most illuminating in American drama, by "one of the most explosively funny American dramatists" – Titanic by Christopher Durang

RICHARD: Victoria, there is no point in continuing this domestic purgatory.

VICTORIA: Not purgatory, Richard. Hell.

RICHARD: Have the decency to control your tongue in front of the boy.

TEDDY: You shouldn't talk about tongue at the table.

RICHARD: Teddy, are you trying to give us difficulty?

VICTORIA: Don't be harsh with Teddy, Richard, he's confused. Have you spoken to him about that bad word beginning with "m" yet? He's that age.

RICHARD: What bad word beginning with "m"? Menstruation?

VICTORIA: No, silly, that's girls. Masturbation.

TEDDY: Oh, that bad word beginning with "m". I thought you meant "mother."

VICTORIA: Give me your leg, Teddy.

TEDDY: You shouldn't talk about leg at the table.

VICTORIA: This pre-pubescent temper tantrum is to stop this instant. GIVE ME YOUR LEG. (She grabs his leg. Shrieking, Victoria tears off the bottom part of Teddy's pants legs, making his long pants now short pants. This is a sudden

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and insane motion and is quite ferocious. Upon completion of her task, Victoria returns to a calm restrained manner.) You are obviously too young for long pants.

TEDDY: Mommy, everyone is staring at us.

RICHARD: Victoria, perhaps we should stay together for the sake of the children.

VICTORIA: Richard, Teddy is not your son.

RICHARD: Victoria, what do you mean?

VICTORIA: Richard, when you married me you looked down on my American ways. You made fun of the pig farm and my mother! One night, after you had ridiculed my boeuf de dordelaise – I went out to our beach and I wept. And on the beach I met a derelict. It was a mad moment, but he is Teddy's father.

RICHARD: I'm only surprised that Teddy's father was a derelict on the beach rather than one of your mother's prize hogs. Victoria, I have something to tell you. Annabella is not your daughter. Harriet Lindsay is Annabella's mother.

VICTORIA: Nonsense. I remember the placenta.

RICHARD: It was all a trick. Harriet and I did it with mirrors.

VICTORIA: I went through all that labor for nothing!!!??

TEDDY: Please don't argue.

VICTORIA: Richard, I shall now make one thing clear. THERE NEVER WAS AN ANNABELLA. Harriet Lindsay and I have been having an affair, and she just invented a pregnancy to keep you from getting suspicious. You never even slept with her. We did it all with mirrors and white bread. HAH! I trust you'll be more careful next time I say something is just marmalade.

RICHARD: (Stands) Victoria, I shall sue you for divorce. Good evening (Exits in a rage)

VICTORIA: You should have thrown your glass of water at your father, Teddy. He insulted your mother.

TEDDY: (Looks in his glass). There's a guppy in my glass.

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VICTORIA: Manners are manners. Oh, look. The Captain is looking our way. Finish your dinner, Teddy. I'm going to the cabin to rest. (She exits. Enter Lidia. Lidia comes to the table.)

(SCENE)

LIDIA: I'm the Captain's daughter Lidia. You're cute. May I sit down?

TEDDY: Are you at the right table?

LIDIA: It is my task to make the guests feel at ease. Your fly is open. No, leave it open. Better for circulation. My father thinks I'm promiscuous for my age. What do you think?

TEDDY: I don't know your age.

LIDIA: We were all listening to your parents. DO you think your father really slept with white bread?

TEDDY: (Shrugs) It might be a metaphor.

LIDIA: I used to keep a hedgehog up my dress. (Pause) But my parents made me stop because I kept feeding it in public. I think that's being fussy. (Pause) I got a funny disease. They thought it was Dutch Elm disease, but it wasn't. Am I boring you?

TEDDY: No. (Teddy gulps his water, a little afraid. Clutching his throat) Does anything happen to you if you swallow a guppy?

LIDIA: Come to my cabin, Teddy. You can't stay a virgin forever.

TEDDY: It's been such a trying day.

LIDIA: Relax. Take your clothes off. I'll get the rope.

TEDDY: Rope?

LIDIA: Boy, you are a novice. (Smiles, pulls him away. Teddy begins to wail. It segues into a Foghorn sound, then into a creaking door as it opens on the Captain's quarters).

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(SCENE – CAPTAIN"S QUARTERS)

CAPTAIN: Well, here we are, Mrs. Tammurai.

VICTORIA: What a lovely cabin, Captain. Why all this pet food?

CAPTAIN: My daughter has a fondness for animals. How can we make the mood right?

VICTORIA: The usual ways. Soft music. Dim lights. Bread.

CAPTAIN: You're an unusual woman, Mrs. Tammurai.

VICTORIA: I've seen too much of the world. (She sighs. Segue into Foghorn. Sailor is on deck with spy glass. Enter Richard)

(SCENE – ON DECK)

RICHARD: Hello, sailor. You look familiar. No, I doubt it could be the same one.

SAILOR: Sir?

RICHARD: Well, this is going to sound silly – but do you go around in drag much?

SAILOR: I've never dressed as a woman in my entire life, sir.

RICHARD: Well, I guess you're not Dicky Miller. I could never tell, of course, unless you dressed up as Queen Victoria. We'd all be sitting round the bar, and in would waltz Dicky with three tiaras on and a tiny poodle stuffed in his bosom. "I am Queen Victoria," he'd say. We'd all play along. "Sorry, Your Majesty, no women allowed in his club," we'd say. Dickey would say, "I am not a woman; I am the Queen." Strange fellow, Dicky. We used to play along with him; we stopped though when one of the poodles smothered to death in Dicky's bodice. It kind of put an edge on things.

SAILOR: Doesn't sound like a regular guy to me.

RICHARD: Oh, he was. Give you the blouse off his back, he would.

SAILOR: Are you a member of Parliament, sir?

RICHARD: No. I'm just a poor should looking for friendship on this bitch of an earth out in the middle of this bitch of a sea.

SAILOR: I think I see an iceberg!

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RICHARD: Really? Where?

SAILOR: Good God! We're heading right for it!

RICHARD: Then we're done for. Sailor, before we go down, I wonder if you'd do me one small favor.

SAILOR: No time for that! I've got to find the Captain (He exits. Foghorn segues into Teddy's moan. Lidia's cabin. Teddy is bound in bed. Lidia is smoking a cigarette.)

(SCENE – Lidia's Quarters)

TEDDY: I had no idea it would be so awful.

LIDIA: The first is always awful.

TEDDY: Why is it necessary that the man be tied?

LIDIA: So the woman can be safe, dopey.

TEDDY: The hamsters bit me.

LIDIA: You men are always complaining. Just be glad I got rid of the hedgehog.

(Squeaking door. Enter the Captain.)

CAPTAIN: Lidia, did you see a woman pass through here?

LIDIA: No I didn't. What are you up to?

CAPTAIN: I was entertaining in my cabin, but the woman seems to have slipped away.

(Squeaking door. Enter the Sailor and Richard.)

SAILOR: Begging pardon, sir, but we've sighted an iceberg.

CAPTAIN: I' ve told you not to bother me in quarters, Higgins. (calling) Mrs. Tammurai!

SAILOR: I'm afraid we're going to sink. Why will no one listen?

RICHARD: Poor chap.

TEDDY: Daddy!

RICHARD: Teddy! What are you . . . (Sees Lidia) Oh, my Got. Is it you?

LIDIA: Certainly not. I'm the Captain's daughter, Lidia.

RICHARD: Harriet.

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LIDIA: Why did you call me Harriet?

RICHARD: You can't fool me. What bread or no white bread, I remember harriet Lindsay.

TEDDY: Then this is the mother of my sister Annabella –

RICHARD: Shut up, Teddy. There is no Annabella.

(Door creaks. Enter Victoria.)

CAPTAIN: Mrs. Tammurai!

RICHARD: Victoria!

VICTORIA: Richard. The Captain is attempting to violate my bread box.

RICHARD: You can run a whole wheat brothel as far as I'm concerned.

TEDDY: I'm all tied up.

LIDIA: Hello, Victoria.

VICTORIA: Oh, my God. Harriet. You've come back.

CAPTAIN: I don't understand. Who is Harriet?

VICTORIA: She is.

CAPTAIN: But this is my daughter Lidia.

VICTORIA: Certainly I can be expected to recognize my own sister Harriet!

RICHARD: I didn't realize Harriet was your sister!

VCTORIA: There are many things you don't realize, Richard.

CAPTAIN: But I don't understand. What is the meaning of this Lidia?

VICTORIA: This is not Lidia. This is my sister Harriet.

TEDDY: I'm still tied up.

VICTORIA: Teddy. That's dirty! Big boys don't sleep with their aunts. Harriet, Teddy is too young to be treated in a carnal manner.

CAPTAIN: I don't understand. Who is Harriet?

LIDIA: (Triumphant.) I am Harriet Lindsay, sister of Victoria Tammurai.

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CAPTAIN: My daughter Lidia was blond. You're not blond – now that I look. Where is my daughter?

LIDIA: Your daughter Lidia is in locker #2838 in Port Authority Bus Terminal in New York and has been for three years.

RICHARD: I am appalled.

VICTORIA: Don 't speak of morals, Richard. I know all about your secret life. Masquerading as royalty, suffocating poodles. Oh, it's so sordid.

TEDDY: Are you my sister Annabella?

LIDIA: What if I am?

TEDDY: Then there really is an Annabella?

LIDIA: Yes.

TEDDY: And there isn't a Harriet?

LIDIA: I suppose not.

TEDDY: Why haven't mommy and daddy recognized you?

LIDIA: Because they're very bad parents.

VICTORIA: Children, children!

TEDDY: (A true realization) Yes, they are. They're very bad. Do you think the boat will ever dock and we can get away from them?

LIDIA: The syip isn't going to dock. It's going to sink.

VICTORIA: Harriet –

LIDIA: Why did you call me Harriet?

VICTORIA: What?

LIDIA: I thought you had caught on by now. Teddy caught on. I AM YOUR DAUGHTER ANNABELLA.

VICTORIA: What do you mean? There is no Annabella. It was a trick you and I played on Richard.

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LIDIA: I've tricked you, mother. You never had an affair with your sister Harriet. You had an affair with me. You don't even have a sister. You're an only child.

VICTORIA: I was a lonely child. (Slaps her) Don't you ever play with words that way again. (Teddy slaps Victoria) Teddy! (Richard slaps Teddy) Thank you, Richard. (Lidia slaps Richard. Victoria slaps Lidia. Teddy slaps Victoria and Richard).

SAILOR: Captain, pleas sir! We're going to ram the iceberg! I'm afraid we're done for. That berg's going to rip right through us.

CAPTAIN: Higgins. I heard you the first time.

(They exit. Loud crash. Sounds of enormous ripping, water gushing, alarms, etc. Various shipwreck chaos. Then the Captain's voice comes over the loudspeaker).

CAPTAIN: This is your Captain speaking. Do no panic. We have not hit an iceberg. What you have just heard is a sound effects record. My wife put it on. It is her idea of a little joke. There is no cause for alarm.

(Sudden crash. Everyone is thrown to the ground)

CAPTAIN: (On loudspeaker) Would anyone seeing a woman carrying a sound effects record please advise the Captain of this fact as soon as possible? Thank you.

LIDIA: (Hating life) Oh, why won't we sink, why?

RICHARD: Annabella, please.

VICTORIA: Richard, you called Harriet Annabella. Really, what could you have been thinking of?

RICHARD: Victoria, mistakes happen.

VICTORIA: Well, I suppose they do.

RICHARD: I forgive you with the derelict on the beach, if you forgive me.

VICTORIA: That's a generous offer, Richard. (Enter the Captain).

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CAPTAIN: I've just been through a rather harrowing experience. We've had to execute my wife. It's nautical law. You're not allowed to incite to sinking. We hanged her from the mast.

VICTORIA: Oh, Captain, how difficult for you.

CAPTAIN: Well, the others did it actually. I just blew the whistle. Mrs. Tammurai? Now that my wife is dead, I would like to propose to you.

RICHARD: Perhaps I should leave.

VICTORIA: Richard's such a gentleman. How did your wife die?

CAPTAIN: I had her executed.

VICTORIA: Oh yes, of course.

CAPTAIN: Nautical law.

VICTORIA: Well, that happens at sea. Sad. Someday I shall face my death, and look back and see my life. And what shall I see? Deceit. Mirrors. White bread. Ah, Captain, you remember the bread. Isn't love a strange thing? (Thinks) Sometimes, I worry. (laughs) And sometimes, I don't (serious) Richard, we're sinking.

RICHARD: Victoria, this is the end. (The end has gurgles and bubbles in his speech, followed by humming the Titanic theme as if sung underwater.)

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AWARD HISTORY

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